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Roscoe Mitchell

Multi-instrumentalist, composer, and visual artist Roscoe Mitchell has been in the forefront of creative music since the late 1960s. He was a founding member of the Association for the Advancement of Creative Musicians and the Art Ensemble of Chicago. He has been honored for his work by numerous organizations including the National Endowment of the Arts.

Roscoe was interviewed via Zoom on May 23, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: I want to start out with an interesting quote I read in an interview you did in 1998. It's very short, it says, "I have so many ideas that my head is exploding with ideas." It must have been a productive time for you and I can relate to that because my head is exploding with questions. But I think I'll just ask you first what are you currently working on, either visual art wise or music wise?

RM: Everything. I mean you know I think that like people are going to want to see what people have been doing. I mean you know during this pandemic or whatever. So, and people are going to be looking for information you know. So I'm just doing whatever I can so that I'm prepared to meet the challenges that are going to be ahead.

MR: That's like a sort of a hopeful way of thinking that people are looking for information and hopefully ready to hear it and view it.

RM: Yeah that is. I mean aren't you like that?

MR: I try to be. I think I sometimes watch too much news and it skews my usually-optimistic outlook.

RM: Yeah well I mean you know you have to sort through these issues. But it doesn't hurt, you know, to kind of know what's going on too. So for me it's a kind of a borderline, you know, how much of this do I want to do and how much of that do I want to do. You know if I'm watching TV I like to watch things that I can learn things from, you know, I mean there's plenty of programs on like that you know, and for me a good day is when I can get up and learn something.

MR: I'll have to remember that. I like that. I'm going to take you way back for a moment if I could. Can you recall, when I look at your career and how much exploring you did, I wonder as a child, even before you started on a woodwind, were you constantly exploring sounds?

RM: Well in a way I was. I mean I would say that like the art is on my mother's side of the family. My uncle Charles Commodore Carter was an artist, and he had put together — what he worked with was crayon and he would layer the crayon and then he had a metal

protractor that he'd scrape and to blend the colors. And he did a book about my sisters and myself and our friends, and we were these people from outer space and so on. So the problem with that whole thing was you know he had moved out of our house and into the church, where he was also another pastor in there, and you know when he passed away those books are gone. And I've done everything you know, to try to find them and I can't find them. But I mean they were glorious. But so the art comes from that side of the family. My uncle Arthur was also an artist and he made a lot of art toys when we were growing up. Okay? So, and then the music comes from my father's side of the family. My father was a singer you know, at one time, and he had problems with his vocal cords so he had to stop singing, but I mean I recall him being able to, you know and back then people would be able to imitate instruments and so on, with their voice. So he was really good at that and he would always say to me, "Well you know you need to sing" you know. So I sung when I was young and he said, "Well you need to sing because saxophone players are a dime a dozen you know. But you know I mean and I did sing, like for the family and I think I was pretty good at imitating like Nat King Cole and different people. But you know when I decided to take on the clarinet and saxophone, you know he got behind whatever I wanted to do. He just wanted to see me being interested in something.

MR: Was there moments of, "All right, Roscoe, come and listen to this." Did he have people that he chose for you to hear back then?

RM: Well I mean yeah, he had his list, but more on that side was my brother Norman. Norman, he had all these 78 records, and he called them "killers." He'd say, "Come on over here bruh" and listen to this and listen to that and so on. And that kind of thing. I don't know if you're familiar with the saxophonist Nicky Hill? He was a prominent saxophonist in Chicago you know, and he was friends with Nicky Hill. And he was a very good scatter, you know, a very good scatter. So I would listen to him do that. But he had all these 78 records you know, and then so he would sit me down and have me listen, I remember some things from Billy Taylor, you know, Lester Young, and on and on. Charlie Parker of course. And so that's what got me into paying more attention to the music you know.

MR: I can recall sort of a realization as I was listening to jazz back when I was about your age and starting to sort out the way the music worked, the accompanist, the soloist, maybe starting to realize about song form. Do you recall that sort of realization coming to you?

RM: Well yeah and I took that even further I mean you know 'cause I'm a composer as well. So I have several pieces and CDs and so on that I've put out with the orchestra that I founded when I was teaching at Mills College you know. So yeah, let's see hold it, I've lost my thought for a minute — I've got out several CDs of this — and one of my CDs

76 won the New York Times Award of the Year. And the thing about it is that what I did
77 was went out to Mills College and put together my own 36-piece chamber orchestra and
78 then recorded them all. I work with Gregory Howe of Wide Hive Records, a man that
79 was wide open to new ideas and so on and so forth. My CDs "Conversations" numbers 1
80 and 2 with Craig Taborn and Kikanju Baku I transcribed our improvisations and turned
81 those into like pieces for orchestra. And that gave me a chance to work on improvisation
82 in another whole way where I was able to actually sit down and look at a transcription
83 and then keep on you know taking the next steps in orchestrating it. So and that taught me
84 a lot about how things work. But it doesn't stop there because it gave me the chance to —
85 I already was experiencing doing it in real time, so it gave me the chance to experience it,
86 you know, in another form where I could actually keep working on it. So yeah, I tend to
87 study opposites, you know, because that helps me figure out like what's going on in the
88 middle.
89 MR: Yes I remember reading that quote from you and I thought it was very interesting, and
90 then you had also said, "If you're sitting at home composing you've got time but what
91 you want to get yourself to the point to where you can make these decisions
92 spontaneously." In the context you were talking about the super musician.
93 RM: That's correct, yes.
94 MR: So was standard notation not enough for you in some of your composing? Were there
95 things you wanted instrumentalists to do that really couldn't be written down in standard
96 notation?
97 RM: Well yeah, I've got pieces like that, yeah, I do. I mean I have pieces, let's see I could
98 recall "En Route" was like a piece where people had route cards, you know, and with
99 certain instructions that would happen on the route. Like let's say that you're on route E,
100 you know, and then I may have a card to say, "Meet you on route E and then establish
101 music with you, and then move on to another part of the composition." So and that was
102 an interesting composition because you also had the sound moving, you know, the
103 musicians were moving around on the stage to different positions so play en route was
104 one of the instructions. So you would actually have the sound moving across like that.
105 MR: Did you find that it helps that the audience have some information about your composing
106 thoughts and why you made these choices?
107 RM: Well you know I mean like I taught, you know, I mean well teaching at Mills College
108 was the most time that I've ever taught at one place you know. And so I had a chance to
109 develop all of these lessons and so on. For instance in my improv class the first class was
110 always about everybody do a three minute improv and that way each student could hear,
111 you know, what other people were doing, so the next assignment would be okay so select
112 someone and come back next week and play a duet and be able to explain to the class

what you were working on. So if you don't know what you was working on then you need to figure out how to get yourself to the point to where you can do that kind of thing and develop it. You know I mean and for me I mean the one easy way to do it is make sure you get to the bottom of the thought that you're doing, you know, so you're not just skipping over it. You know you want to stay with a small part of an idea until it starts to reveal itself to you. It's similar to you know sometimes if I'm writing something and then there comes a moment where you know I'm not having to think about it anymore then I'm on the right path to developing it.

MR: Very interesting. It makes me think a little bit about a quote I had a conversation with Karl Berger, the late Karl Berger. And he said — we were talking about sort of free jazz, and he said, "More freedom is not about less precision it's about more precision. The more precise you get the more free you are. People think of a sense of freedom, free jazz, oh I can lose all the rules. I'm actually creating my own rules and they're much more stringent."

RM: Absolutely. He's totally right on that. You know. Totally right. But I go way back with Karl Berger. When I was in the Army in Heidelberg, Germany, there was a K-54 and Karl Berger was down there with the musicians down there — Albert Mangelsdorff was there, Bent Jaedig, the great tenor saxophonist from Denmark, and you know Nathaniel Davis, his quartet had won the All-Army championship or whatever, so they came to live with us in Heidelberg. So I used to hang out with him and go down there and there would always be these sessions and so on and so forth. So yeah, yeah I mean to me I'm glad to be a part of the people that have had the chance to have long term musical relationships. Because there's no way in the world, you know, you can develop this kind of work, you know, without doing that. When we were all in Chicago there, you know we had an agenda, you know, we knew that like we were going to go to the C & C Lounge for the rehearsals with Muhal's Big Band and he would encourage all the musicians in the band to write for the band. And so you'd write for the band and you'd bring your music in to hear it. If he didn't like it you could take it home and change it and so on and so forth. So it always has to be placed in that context. Because a lot of times you might know something but you may not know it at that moment so you may have to just keep working until it starts to reveal itself to you. So, and once that happens then you've got a helper.

MR: All right. I want to take you back a little bit before that and I read that in 1961 you had what this review said, a hard bop group and Joseph Jarman and Anthony Braxton. My question is at that point, in 1961, Coltrane released "My Favorite Things" and Ornette Coleman "Free Jazz," Max Roach had a "Freedom Suite," and one of my favorites, Hank Mobley had an LP called "Roll Call." Was there decision-making for you at that point in your career about your direction?

RM: Well you know like yeah, I had, we had times that we would all go to Berlin to join with the Berlin band there and also the band from Orleans, France was there as well. And who should be in the band from Orleans, France but Albert Ayler you know. And Albert, I heard him way back then and the way I chose the saxophone is what is your sound you know, where is your sound you know. Because all the great players, you know they had a sound that they were pursuing you know. But when I heard Albert you know I didn't know what he was doing but I understood that he had an enormous sound on the instrument you know. So he won me over like right away. I didn't — like I said — I didn't understand exactly what he was doing but he had me there. And like it wasn't until I came back into Chicago, you know, was out of the Army and heard Coltrane doing that album called "Coltrane" on Impulse where he did "Inch Worm" and "Out of this World" and all this stuff with the band that he had with McCoy Tyner and Elvin Jones and Jimmy Garrison. So I thought wow, you mean you can do that or you can do this? 'Cause it was a different approach of improvisation in terms of a modal concept you know. And so I paid attention to that and you know in Chicago too there was McKie Fitzhugh's Club on 64th and Cottage Grove, between 64th and 63rd on Cottage Grove, and there you know on the weekends you go up in there and man, Dexter Gordon, John Coltrane, I mean John Coltrane come to Chicago he had so many dinner invitations. I mean there's no way in the world he could have made all of those you know. So I — just a minute let's see now — I paid attention to that and then during the weekdays they had a local trio, Eddie Buster and the trio that he played with, and you know, and it was a lot of sessioning going on. And then I was going to the sessions and playing and then I kept hearing this strange music you know and I told Eddie I said man I'm hearing this, I'm hearing that, and so he encouraged me to keep moving on that you know? And when I did that then it started kind of like pouring out of me and then you know they were all right there encouraging me to do it.

MR: Eddie who?

RM: Eddie Buster.

MR: Okay.

RM: Yeah. They were all encouraging me to do that because like back then you had like the apprenticeship and so on, where all you had to do was show someone that you wanted to know something from that you were interested and they would take you on and show you like how to do it you know. And so yeah, yeah, it was that kind of environment like in Chicago you know. And so it was all there in a way you know. The off nights it was local musicians and sessions and stuff, but then on the weekend you'd have the big players up in there. So I recall Dexter Gordon was there playing and you know a spring broke on his horn and he needed a rubber band and I just happened to have a rubber band with me you

know, so I gave him that. I mean I guess the next time I saw Dexter was like when the Art Ensemble went to Europe, so he was there in Copenhagen.

MR: I want to ask you about that but sometimes I get this vision in my head when I hear music that is sort of breaking boundaries. I picture gentlemen like yourselves when you were younger sitting around in a late night diner talking about what we could do to make the music different. And I asked that sort of question to Rashied Ali and he answered, "No we never really talked about it we just did it. The guys I was hanging out with we didn't sit down and say now we're going to play in or we're going to play out or no bar lines, it was just something we did spontaneously." Does that ring a bell with you?

RM: Well not really. I mean you know because stepping over to Muhal's arena you know, you're working man. You're working. You're being encouraged. You know if you bring a piece in and you're having some problems with it you were encouraged to go home and change whatever you wanted to do and bring your piece back because Muhal used to always say, you know, "You need to get it right you know, because if you don't every time you listen to it you're going to hear an unfinished part there" so like I'm saying you were encouraged to do these things and then having a big band to write for, yeah man, Muhal was writing these pieces like Fats — you know, Fats Waller — the stride piano. He would spend — you know I was in college at that time and I'd leave college and go right over to Muhal's house and then be there you know until the evening and stuff, and he would still come to — and I wasn't the only one there you know — he would still come to the rehearsal on Monday with a new piece you know. So yeah there was differences between Chicago and the style, you know, how the music developed. So, but yeah, nine times out of ten we were there working on the music.

MR: This might be an odd question but did you always think of jazz as an art form?

RM: Absolutely. It's America's classical music you know, in a way. I mean it really is. I mean I think that Duke Ellington, you know, that's not even a real question. Duke Ellington is a master, you know, and all of these people you know, yeah, yeah you know I mean you look at a Bud Powell solo. Jesus Christ you know I mean you know he's just playing whatever he wants to play you know? Thelonious Monk you know.

MR: If people listen to some of your solo alto work do you think that they feel that you're playing whatever you want to play like you said Bud Powell was?

RM: Well I don't know about that but I'll tell you about my experience in Willisau, Switzerland. I was there with the Art Ensemble. We had played a concert. Anthony Braxton could not get there because of something that went wrong with his travel. So Niklaus Troxler, and I don't know if you have this record, do you?

MR: I don't think so.

RM: Well you need to get it you know. It's the "Nonaah" record you know. Niklaus Troxler asked me if I would play the solo in the place of Anthony. And so like I said, I'd already played with the Art Ensemble. So when I went on the stage to take the stage, you had people that didn't like that you know. And they had decided that they were going to like shout me down you know. So I just picked one of the repetitions. You know you need to get some of my records you know. And then you can understand more clearly like what I'm talking about and like Chuck Nessa has these recordings you know. You know so they were determined to shout me down you know and so I just got into the repetition of this composition and I started to play it over and over and over and over. And then variate it gradually and so on. Yeah, now I want you to get this record you know, and then maybe you can write me sometime in the future and tell me what you think of it. You know. But I hit this same repetition over and over and over and variating it so slightly and then all different kinds of ways until the audience was solid, and then I went on to finish my solo version of "Nonaah." You know. "Nonaah" is a piece that you know started out as a projected one of five projected compositions for solo saxophone. What I wanted to do with that piece was to give the impression of the saxophone sounding like more than one instrument. So I used wide interval skips to exploit the registers. I might play something in the low register and then something in the middle register, the high register, the altissimo register — not a line that's in the scale fashion but in skips and so on.

MR: When I heard it I imagined it in an etude book and getting to that page and saying oh there's no way I'm going to be able to play this.

RM: Are you a saxophonist?

MR: I am a saxophone player yes.

RM: Oh. You can play it but you've just got to stay with it.

MR: Yeah okay.

RM: Because like man I'm here working like a dog right now man, you know, I mean trying to figure out all different kinds of ways to memorize things more quickly and so on, and then sometimes I get so wrapped up in the stuff and I forget the stuff that I'm working on you know so then I'll be playing — "Oh I used to play that, I used to play this, I used to do this, I used to do that." So and then I'm pulling all that back out you know, so that I'm doing that. Because I'm working on memory you know and trying to — so, and it's working. I'll tell you a good book is Jackie McLean's book you know. Do you know that book?

MR: Yes I do.

RM: Yeah, that's a good book man, he takes you to all those choruses and so on and then at the end you have the grand exercises and so on and so on and so forth you know. I mean Jackie Mac is a mean individual. You know. I mean [scats] you know, the thing on

"Stella By Starlight" you know so yeah man, you know there's no lack of things to do. No lack of things to do.

MR: In your career as time went by and you saw other jazz musicians seemingly selling a lot of records and we think that makes money for them, that may or may not be true. But did you ever look at that and say — be tempted to go that route? Soul jazz or fusion?

RM: No I ain't tempted by nothing but what I want to do. You know there's something that guides me you know. You know like I said, a good day for me is when I can wake up and learn something you know. And music is like hey I need more than one lifetime to learn as much about music as I would like to know. So I give in to that. I give in to that you know. I mean and I'm studying all kinds of music you know. Early music you know. I play the transverso — the flute with six holes and one key that's down at the bottom. This is the instrument that Bach wrote for you know.

MR: The Baroque flute you're talking about.

RM: Yeah, the Baroque flute, that's right, the Baroque flute I do play that. The entire recorder family, I play that as well. Because I've been in several early music groups. So wow, I have a whole collection of instruments that I made that no one even has. Percussion instruments and so on that I play. So there I mean everybody can be an individual because I encourage people that are interested in it, you know, to build their own instrument you know. So that way then everybody has their own instrument. But you know there's a language that can be created you know with those instruments. So like I — at one time I did a lot of work with Steven Sylvester who is an inventor you know that — he, you know he came to me and he said, "You know what I'm going to do is I'm going to build an instrument that can keep up with you." And so our first concert was where you know he decided to take a bullroarer, which comes from Australia, you know, and put it on a motor he had at first and then a couple of days before the concert he decided wait a minute, I'm going to put this on pedal power you know. And he put it on pedal power and so when he did that all of a sudden the instrument started to breathe because if you look at somebody who's riding a bike it looks like that it's a kind of a smooth thing but it's not, it's a breathing spot as that cycle goes around like that. So it started to breathe after that. And I have all of these deals and so on and so forth. I mean you know yeah I mean it's a big story. Yeah, our last concert with that group, I mean it was in Atlanta. And you know Steven Sylvester, once he put this thing on pedal power I mean he just — his first instrument was a thing where he had the pallet on the side of his head where he'd stuck them up there with some kind of sticky thing and so on. The next one was, it was a long line over the top of his head with triggers in different things so he could let out different sounds and so on. He had these little small metal tubes that he made with slits in them, you know, when they were going fast — ooooo — and when

they were going slow they were hitting each other like little bells and ringing and so on and so forth you know. So yeah, yeah, I mean I learn a lot from him man. You know, really.

MR: You seem to be constantly curious.

RM: Yes. I am. I'm constantly curious. Now even more so than ever. Now even more so than ever.

MR: In the groups you've had, some have been what I would guess, assume is, democratically collective, but others that you formed as a leader — you can correct me if I'm not correct but I'm wondering how you guided or directed people in the group if they weren't performing in a way that helped to fulfill your basic idea.

RM: Well you know we rehearsed man. You know. We rehearsed every day you know. I mean like you wouldn't have to ask me what are you doing Monday through Friday — you know — we're rehearsing you know. From about nine to five every day. That's what we're doing. You know. I mean like you can't, you know if you take music for granted you lose, you lose. You take music for granted you lose. So and I mean even if you have rehearsed well, and you might still think you're not doing that great, but when you go back and listen to it you are actually doing something.

MR: Are the expectations in — I wish there was a better term than free jazz. Maybe you have one.

RM: There is no such thing as free jazz.

MR: Okay well thank you.

RM: There is no such thing as free jazz.

MR: Because?

RM: Because not hard as I'm working. You know. There's no such thing as free jazz. You know that's just something that critics came up with you know.

MR: Do you think that Ornette Coleman's LP back in '61 was an unfortunate —

RM: It was a monster. It was a monster. Ornette Coleman's record is a monster you know, him and Don Cherry and Charlie Haden, Ed Blackwell. That is some stellar music.

MR: But did he call it free jazz do you know?

RM: Well I don't know, I don't know what he called it but I mean it's not free jazz. You get up there and do what Ornette Coleman did. That ain't no free jazz man. You know. And there was piece —all of these pieces you know, like that, that beautiful ballad that Ornette wrote you know. Ornette was a stellar musician you know.

MR: And he paid a lot of dues for what he did.

RM: I don't think that he did. I mean like in the end he triumphed and won. You know everybody knew like you know you don't become Ornette Coleman by not knowing what you're doing. You know you don't do that.

MR: Well I would venture that I could say the same thing about you.

RM: What would you say about me?

MR: I would say that you spent a great deal of time and energy developing your own style and that when I look at your output and the acknowledgement that you've gotten from, through NEA Jazz Master and other recognitions that you have triumphed also.

RM: Well you know I mean I haven't triumphed until the end. I mean like you know you can't — once you get to the point where your head has got so big that you don't think you can learn anything you're finished. That's it. You're finished. Like I said, again, a good day for me is when I can wake up and learn something. That's a good day.

MR: Well this has been a good day for me in that regard then. So thank you for sharing that.

RM: All right, you're quite welcome.

MR: Yeah. When the Art Ensemble went to Paris for a couple of years, can you share what the motivation was? Was it audience? Was there any racial considerations about going abroad?

RM: No. No. Claude Delcloo reached out to the ACM and was asking about information about going there. And I mean like we had already been to California two times in a row you know. So but that was interesting as well because the first time we went there it was with Lester Bowie and Philip Wilson and myself. And Nick Gravenitis was there doing, managing Big Brother and the Holding Company with Ron Polte. And I did a recording with Nick Gravenitis before, you know, he went out to California, "My Baby's Got a Whole Lot of Soul" it's called. So they had a house out there that they had got for Mike Bloomfield I believe it was and Buddy Guy — not Buddy Guy, God — Buddy Miles you know. They were going to put together a band. But they weren't living in the house for another 30 days so they gave us the house. It was in Mill Valley. So we lived there and we had a couple of records out then and I believe "Sound" was out and also "Lester Bowie's Numbers One and Two" were out. So we would go over to Mill Valley and practice and then we were running out of money we would go into San Francisco and sell some CDs and stuff and then go back to Mill Valley. And by the way we were out there in Lester Bowie's — let's see now there's Rolls Royce — oh Bentley. There was a Bentley, a green Bentley. Lester lived large, big, always big ideas you know. Just full of them you know. I mean like when we were getting ready to go to Europe he took out an ad in the *Chicago Defender* and said, you know, musician sells out. And what he was doing was selling all of his furniture and everything, his possessions, to take the band to Europe you know. That's what he did you know. Lester Bowie, wow, always full of big ideas. Big ideas. You know, encouraging and so on. So I mean like when Lester left I was faced with the question well why didn't I ask Lester this, why didn't I ask Lester that and so on like that you know. So yeah, it's been a journey you know. And Malachi [Favors],

oh my God you know all of these people in the Art Ensemble. I mean Joseph. So now Don [Moye] and myself, we may start to do some duet concerts so that's the thing that we're thinking about right now. And then that's — that's the way we had talked about the Art Ensemble you know we said the Art Ensemble is the Art Ensemble until the last person standing is gone you know. So we had discussed that so it was already forecast in a way.

MR: Long term commitment.

RM: Yes.

MR: Let me ask you about your visual art, which — didn't you have the cover art on Lester's thing that you just mentioned?

RM: Yeah, yeah. Lester Bowie's Numbers One and Two" yes. It was at the opening in Chicago.

MR: What is the medium that you work in?

RM: Well I had some crossover things from when I was doing oils so I finished those up, but I'm doing acrylics now. Because I don't want to breathe all of the oils and all this kind of thing like that anymore. So yeah I'm using acrylics and I use a brush and then also I use these pens you know, because they're almost like drawing. Yeah, yeah. So that's what I'm doing. But of course but John Corbett went back and found, looked under every rock and stone and found every painting that I darn near ever did in my life. You know John Corbett is a man that doesn't have the word no in his vocabulary.

MR: Well it's a nice, sort of continuing the circle that perhaps your uncle started with his crayons.

RM: Yeah, yeah, yeah it is.

MR: There was another, going back to this interview you did in 1998, you said, "Everything goes in a circle." You were talking about the 60s before and we're in the 90s now, that's a complete circle. I believe you were talking about how music was being accepted. And where are we on the circle now? Do you think that the music that you've created recently is resonating with a significant audience?

RM: Oh absolutely. Yeah. Every day I get up just something will happen. You know? I mean it's kind of — and then I try to align myself with people that are thinking in a similar way because there's a lot of people, and it's a good time to make a connection with people. You know? So yeah, I tend to lean on that side of things.

MR: You sound like you're an optimist?

RM: I am. I mean I'm not going to be a pessimist, that's no fun. You know. I mean like if you are saying no, I can't use you. I'm looking for somebody saying yes. Why do I want to be bothered with no? You know? Because there's a lot of people out there, and I know this is true, there's a lot of people out there saying yes.

MR: I mean I've had checks not show up for me, but not in this project going the other way. All right. Well thank you for your time Mr. Mitchell, it's been a great pleasure.

RM: All right thank you so much.

MR: Okay.

RM: All right.